CB have written to point out that this despatch is on the wrong type of paper.

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United Kingdom Liaison Mission in Japan,
British Embassy,
TOKYO.

CONFIDENTIAL
1030/50/52

4th February, 1952.

No. 23

FO 371/10310/47

Sir,

The Japanese Prime Minister, in his attempts to clarify the issue of Japan's relations with China and the Soviet Union, succeeds in confusing it. He has made statements in the Diet on the question of his letter of the 24th December and of Japan's relations both with China and with the Soviet Union which can hardly give satisfaction to anyone. It is true that Ministers' replies to interpellations in the Japanese Diet are impromptu and that except for a general indication of the subject no notice is given of the exact nature of the questions to be asked. This practice is conducive to ill-considered and rash ministerial statements, but it may also provide a more accurate indication of the speaker's frame of mind than would be the case if he were replying on the basis of a carefully phrased official brief.

2. In the House of Councillors on the 25th January Mr. Yoshida, according to the "Official Gazette", replied to an interpellation to the effect that there had always been close connections between Japan and China and it would be excellent if, on the basis of these close connections, it were possible to establish friendly relations between the two countries. However, apart from differences in ideology and policy, the Peking regime was threatening the internal security of Japan. The Sino-Soviet Treaty,

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His Majesty's
Principal Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs,
Foreign Office.

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which was devised in Moscow, was a military alliance directed against Japan, which made it very difficult to enter into negotiations with the Peking regime. Moreover Japan had promised to cooperate with the United Nations and Japan could not enter into negotiations with a government with which they were in conflict. On the other hand the Government of Formosa was a member of the United Nations and was recognised as such by a large number of powers. Japan had close geographical and historical connections with Formosa and already had an Overseas Agency there. The Formosan Government had control over the island and it was natural that the Japanese Government should enter into negotiations with it. The United States Government, Mr. Yoshida went on, understood Japanese policy on this question. He had given his opinion on this subject in his letter to Mr. Dulles as the latter had told him that a letter of this kind would hasten ratification of the Peace Treaty in the United States Senate. If this were considered pressure, Mr. Yoshida did not understand the meaning of the term. It had been said that the British Government disapproved of his letter but he believed they fully understood his meaning. At least the Japanese Government had not received any protests from the British Government.

3. So far so good. But on the very next day in the House of Councillors, Mr. Yoshida chose to advance arguments of sweet reasonableness to the other side. The Japanese Government, he said, did not consider that the Nationalist Government in Formosa represented the whole of

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China or that the proposed establishment of diplomatic relations with that Government meant that Japan was entering upon a Peace Treaty with a Government representing the whole country. In view of the close geographical and historical relations between China and Japan, he desired to improve relations with continental China and deplored the fact that this was impossible under present circumstances. This did not, however, mean that efforts to improve such relations had been suspended. "We intend", he said, "to improve these relations".

4. On the 29th January Mr. Yoshida took advantage of an interpellation by a member of the Ryokufukai on Japan's future relations with the Soviet Union to straighten out matters with that country. Apart from ideological considerations, he said, Japan could not enter into peaceful relations with the Soviet Government until all existing "unpleasant factors" had been removed. These included the 300,000 unrepatriated Japanese, the occupation by the Soviet Union of Shikotan island and the Habomai group and the Sino-Soviet Treaty of 1950. When all these unpleasantnesses had been "dissolved", Mr. Yoshida concluded, Japan would be prepared to enter into peaceful relations with the Soviet Union. These sentiments on the part of the Prime Minister might have been regarded as unexceptionable were it not for the doubt which prevails as to his Government's views about the attendance of Japanese representatives at the forthcoming Moscow Economic Conference. On the same day that he spoke, Japanese industrialists met a member of the Soviet Mission

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to discuss Soviet-Japanese trade.

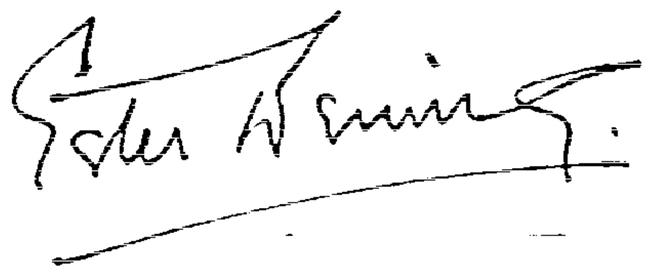
5. The present session of the Japanese Diet has only lasted a fortnight, and it is conceivable that Mr. Yoshida will have many more things to say about Japan's relations with China and the Soviet Union, none of which will provide a real clue to Japan's intentions. These have probably not altered as a result of all that has passed, and Japan would no doubt still like to establish a modus vivendi with the Central People's Government of China and with the Soviet Union as well as with Chiang Kai-shek, and to retain the goodwill and help of the United States into the bargain. All this might be achieved if Mr. Yoshida would hold his tongue. He is known to prefer silence, and perhaps this is because he realises that he is incapable of discretion when he speaks impromptu. As it is, his Diet performances do not enhance his stature or inspire confidence in the future trustworthiness in international affairs of the government which he leads.

I am sending copies of this despatch to His Majesty's Representatives at Washington, Moscow and Peking and to the Commissioner General for the United Kingdom in South East Asia at Singapore.

I have the honour to be, with the highest respect,

Sir,

Your most obedient, humble Servant.



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